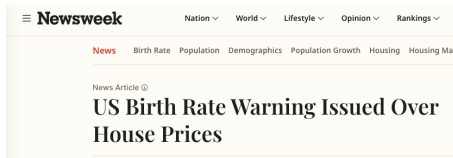


Fertility and Housing Tenure Choice

Tommaso De Santo

September 14, 2026

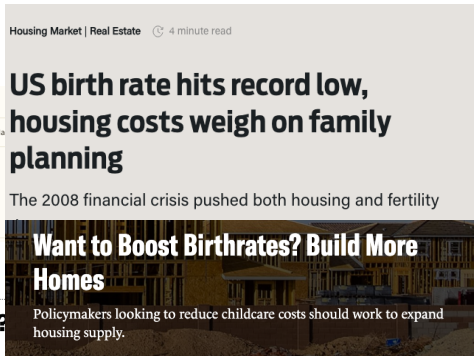
Housing and Fertility



POLICY

Will cheap housing lead to more babies?

The connection between housing and fertility rates has a missing piece.



Renting a home 'leads to lower birth rates'

Housing, Fertility, and Tenure Choice

Housing costs affect fertility, but tenure and wealth matter:

- Owners have more children when house prices or housing wealth rise; renters do not (Dettling & Kearney 2014)
- Easier mortgage credit raises buying and births jointly, especially through purchases of larger homes (Hacamo 2021; Couillard 2025)

Children increase how much physical space a household needs. This has implications for:

- **Owning**: large units are disproportionately owner occupied
- **Wealth**: the down payment determines access to family-sized housing
- **Age**: much of the large owner stock remains with older households

How much does access to physical space affect fertility?

Can housing policy increase fertility, and through which margins?

→ space constraints, tenure choice, and demographic feedback

This Paper

Need a structural model where fertility, tenure, saving, and population scale are jointly determined.

Model: lifecycle model of sequential fertility, tenure, housing size, and saving

- Children create a discrete increase in housing need
- Rental-size limits, down payments, transaction costs, income risk, and bequests
- Births create persons; persons create household heads only later

Empirics: document how family formation changes housing demand

- Large units are primarily owned
- First birth raises ownership, rooms, and moves for space

Quantification: fit the lifecycle model, solve the demographic transition, and discipline a rebated property-tax experiment.

Model

Environment

- One national housing market; the active quantitative model has no household location choice
- One period is four years; households enter at age 18 and can live through age 85
- Beginning-of-period state:

$$x = (b, z, a, h, n, m)$$

- b : liquid net wealth; z : earnings state; a : age
 - h : inherited owner size, with $h = 0$ for renters
 - n : literal parity; m : number of dependent children at home
- Households choose whether to attempt the next birth, renter or owner housing, consumption, and saving
- Earnings, child maturation, and survival are stochastic

Preferences

Let m denote the number of dependent children currently at home.

Flow utility. Over consumption and housing services:

$$u_t(c, s; m) = e(m)^{\sigma-1} \frac{\left[c^{\alpha_0} (s - \bar{h}(m))^{1-\alpha_0} \right]^{1-\sigma}}{1-\sigma} + \psi_t m.$$

Family needs.

$$e(m) = \left(\frac{2 + 0.7m}{2} \right)^{0.7}, \quad \bar{h}(m) = h_1 \mathbf{1}\{m > 0\} + h_m m.$$

Housing services.

$$s = \begin{cases} h^R, & \text{renter,} \\ \chi h, & \text{owner,} \end{cases} \quad \chi > 1.$$

- h_1 is the first-child room jump; h_m is the additional floor per child at home.
- Child costs shut off as children mature.

Housing, Tenure, and Budget Constraints

Households choose housing inputs

$$h^R \in [0, 6], \quad h' \in \{0, 2, 4, 6, 8, 10\}, \quad h' h^R = 0.$$

Tenure is implicit: $h^R > 0$ means rent; $h' > 0$ means own.

Changing the inherited owner stock h to h' changes liquid resources by

$$\mathcal{T}_t(h, h') = \mathbf{1}\{h' \neq h\} [(1 - \psi^s)P_t h - P_t h'].$$

Renters ($h' = 0$)

$$c + r_t h^R + b' = R_b b + y(a, z) + \mathcal{T}_t(h, 0) + T_t.$$

Owners ($h^R = 0$)

$$c + (\delta_H + \tau_t^P)P_t h' + b' = R_b b + y(a, z) + \mathcal{T}_t(h, h') + T_t.$$

- A buyer needs cash of at least $(1 - \phi)P_t h'$, with financed share $\phi = 0.80$.
- The debt floor rules out new unsecured borrowing and tapers inherited debt with age.

Sequential Fertility and Child Aging

- During fertile ages, a household at parity $n < 3+$ chooses whether to attempt the next birth.
- An attempt succeeds with age-specific probability π_a .
- A successful birth:

$$n' = n + 1, \quad m' = m + 1,$$

and the first successful birth pays the one-time cost F_1 .

- Fertility taste shocks have scale κ_1 on the first-birth margin and κ_C on continuation margins.
- Each child at home matures independently; m falls as children leave, while parity n remains a stock.
- A birth changes the person stock immediately. It affects the number of household heads only later through survival and household formation.

Earnings and Bequests

Earnings

- Lifecycle earnings profile
- Five-state persistent Markov process
- Three permanent-income types
- Retirement income after working life
- Liquid return R_b

Warm-glow bequests

$$\mathcal{B}(w^e) = \theta_0 \frac{(\theta_1 + \max\{w^e, 0\})^{1-\sigma}}{1-\sigma}.$$

- Estate wealth includes liquid assets and net housing sale proceeds.
- Bequests affect saving and old-age housing retention.
- Entrant wealth is externally distributed: the model is not fully dynastic.

Housing Supply and Price Mapping

Occupied housing demand is the integral of physical rooms:

$$D_t = \int h_t(x) dG_t(x).$$

Static elastic supply is anchored to the fitted 2023 economy:

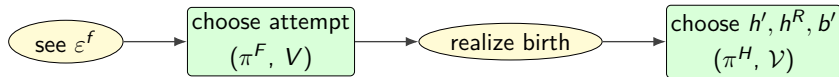
$$H_t^s = H_{2023} \left(\frac{P_t}{P_{2023}} \right)^\eta, \quad D_t = H_t^s.$$

Housing is also an asset. Rent and the current purchase price satisfy

$$r_t + P_{t+1} = (R_b + \delta_H + \tau_t^p)P_t.$$

- P_t capitalizes the next-period resale value.
- r_t is the current renter price.
- Owner service utility χh does not create extra physical housing supply.
- The maintained supply elasticity is $\eta = 1.75$.

The Household's Problem



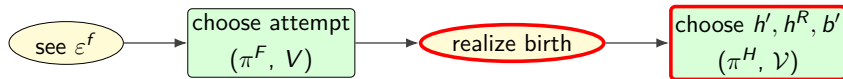
State.

$$x = (b, z, a, h, n, m), \quad h \in \{0, 2, 4, 6, 8, 10\}.$$

- b : liquid wealth; z : earnings; a : age; h : inherited owner stock.
- n : parity; m : number of children currently at home.
- The national location state is degenerate and is suppressed.

Within the period: observe the fertility shock, choose whether to attempt, realize conception success, then choose tenure, rooms, consumption, and saving.

The Household's Problem: Housing and Saving

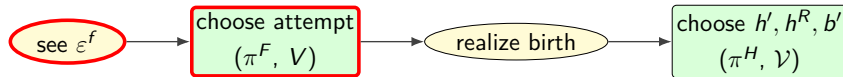


Conditional on the realized parity branch, the post-fertility value is

$$\mathcal{V}_t(x) = \mathbb{E}_{\varepsilon_t^H} \max_{h', h^R, b'} \left\{ u_t(c, s; m) + \varepsilon_t^H(h') + \beta s_a \mathbb{E}_t[V_{t+1}(x')] + \beta(1 - s_a) \mathcal{B}(w_{t+1}^e) \right\}.$$

- $h' h^R = 0$: a renter sets $h' = 0$; an owner sets $h^R = 0$.
- Current purchases occur at P_t and future sales at future prices.
- The budget, down-payment condition, and age-tapered debt floor restrict (h', h^R, b') .
- Household policies use the date- $(t + 1)$ continuation value.

The Household's Problem: Fertility Choice



Let x^+ add one birth, and let π_a be conception success. Before the attempt taste shock:

$$W_t^0(x) = V_t(x), \quad W_t^A(x) = \pi_a [\mathcal{V}_t(x^+) - F_1 \mathbf{1}\{n = 0\}] + (1 - \pi_a) V_t(x).$$

The attempt probability is

$$\pi_t^F(x) = \frac{\exp\{W_t^A(x)/\kappa(n)\}}{\exp\{W_t^A(x)/\kappa(n)\} + \exp\{W_t^0(x)/\kappa(n)\}}, \quad \kappa(n) = \begin{cases} \kappa_1, & n = 0, \\ \kappa_C, & n \geq 1. \end{cases}$$

Housing affects fertility through current child-space needs, tenure feasibility, and the continuation value of wealth and housing.

Persons Are Not Household Heads

2023 stock	Level	Accounting role
Resident persons	338.7 million	Cohorts exposed to survival and migration
Household heads	129.0 million	Economic decision makers
Persons per head	2.63	Ratio of two distinct stocks

- A birth changes the person stock now.
- It can change the head stock only later through survival and household formation.
- The economic household distribution must agree with the head mass implied by persons.

Births Create Persons

Let $N_t^{g,a}$ denote resident persons of sex g and single year of age a .

The annual person law is

$$N_{t+1} = A_{t+1}N_t + f_{t+1}B_{t+1} + M_{t+1}.$$

- A_{t+1} ages existing cohorts using destination-age survival.
- $f_{t+1}B_{t+1}$ allocates newborn survivors by sex at age zero.
- M_{t+1} is the age–sex net-migration flow after survival.
- The four-year birth flow is spread uniformly across calendar years, each with its own sex shares, survival rates, and migration inputs.

Births are never converted mechanically into future household heads by dividing by 2.1.

Persons Create Heads

Fixed age–sex headship rates $\rho^{g,a}$ map persons into the target head stock:

$$H_{t+1}^{g,a} = \rho^{g,a} N_{t+1}^{g,a} = H_{t+1}^{\text{surv},g,a} + F_{t+1}^{g,a} - D_{t+1}^{g,a} + H_{t+1}^{M,g,a}.$$

The household operator supplies a raw within-age distribution $\tilde{G}_{t+1,a}$. Its mass is rescaled to the person-law head target:

$$G_{t+1,a}(x) = H_{t+1,a} \frac{\tilde{G}_{t+1,a}(x)}{\int \tilde{G}_{t+1,a}(x') dx'}.$$

- F and D are the minimum one-way formation or dissolution flow needed to attain $\rho^{g,a}$.
- Wealth, tenure, income, parity, and child-state composition are preserved within age.
- This is an accounting closure, not an estimated household-formation hazard.

Transition Equilibrium

A perfect-foresight transition is a path

$$\{V_t, \pi_t, G_t, N_t, H_t, P_t, r_t, T_t\}_{t=2023}^T$$

such that, at every date:

1. households optimize given future prices and transfers;
2. births advance persons and heads, and the household distribution is rebalanced to head mass;
3. occupied housing equals static-elastic supply;
4. the asset-price/rent identity holds;
5. property-tax revenue equals the equal transfer paid to household heads.

The Corrected Steady State

A steady state is a constant tuple

$$(N^*, H^*, G^*, \pi^*, P^*, r^*, T^*)$$

that satisfies simultaneously:

- household optimality and household-distribution stationarity;
- the person-cohort fixed point under the stated survival and migration closure;
- head formation and exact agreement between head mass and household mass;
- housing-market clearing, asset pricing, the government budget, and demographic reproduction.

A finite path is not a steady state. Neither is a constant household distribution whose births fail to reproduce persons and heads.

Summary

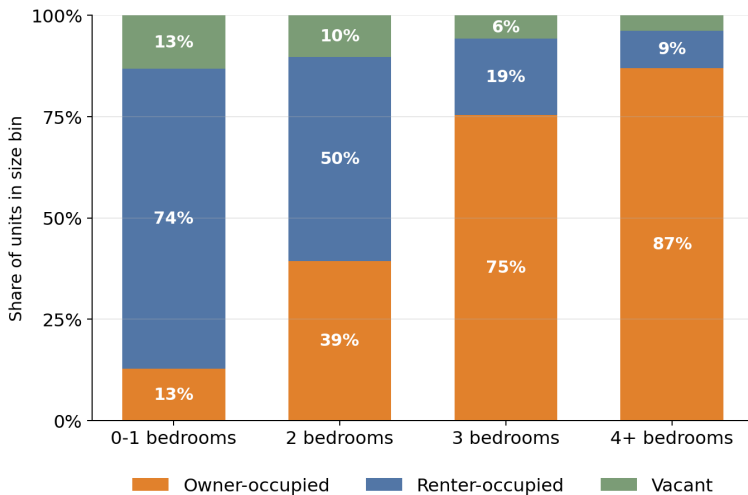
- A lifecycle model of sequential fertility, housing size, tenure, saving, income risk, and bequests
- Children raise housing needs immediately; rental limits and down payments restrict access
- Births, resident persons, and household heads move on different clocks
- The model predicts:
 - childbirth raises demand for rooms and ownership
 - inherited age structure creates demographic and housing-market momentum
 - housing policy changes both current family formation and future market scale
- The data can:
 - discipline the child-space and tenure margins
 - identify where the quantitative model succeeds and fails

Empirics

Data

- **American Community Survey and American Housing Survey**
 - Ownership, occupied rooms, family composition, age, and headship
 - Allocation of large owner-occupied units across the lifecycle
- **Panel Study of Income Dynamics**
 - Longitudinal fertility, rooms, tenure, wealth, income, and reasons for moving
 - First-birth event study and family-size housing contrasts
- **Current Population Survey and natality records**
 - Completed fertility, childlessness, and first-birth timing
- **Survey of Consumer Finances**
 - Aggregate and old-age wealth moments

Big Units Are Owned



Using the PSID: Event-Study Design

Let E_i denote household i 's first-birth year. For a housing outcome Y_{it} :

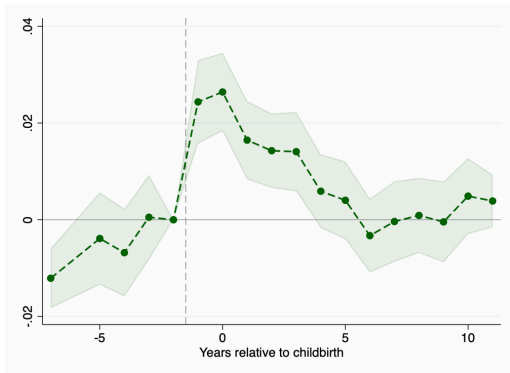
$$Y_{it} = \sum_{k=-5, k \neq -2}^{10} \alpha_k \mathbf{1}\{t - E_i = k\} + \zeta_i + \tau_t + \delta X_{it} + \varepsilon_{it}.$$

- ζ_i and τ_t are household and calendar-year fixed effects.
- The displayed descriptive plots use $k = -2$ as the omitted period.
- PSID transitions are measured from the previous observed interview; the survey is biennial after 1997.
- The active rooms target uses a separate Sun–Abraham $k = -1$ to $k = +3$ contrast.
- Because that target has a non-flat prepath, it is used for calibration but not interpreted causally.

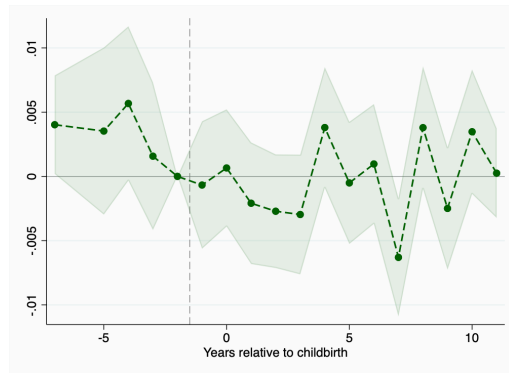
PSID: Childbirth Raises Moves for Space

$\hat{\alpha}_k$: change in moving probability relative to $k = -2$.

$Y = \mathbf{1}\{\text{moved for expansion of housing}\}$



$Y = \mathbf{1}\{\text{moved for neighborhood quality}\}$

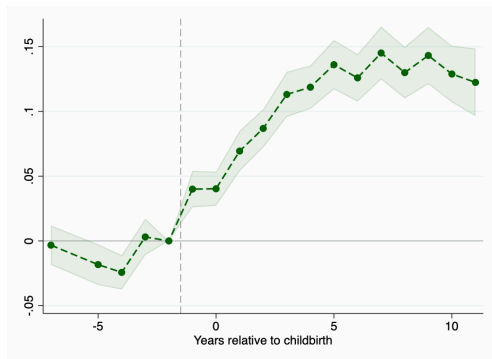


- The probability of moving for housing size rises around first birth.
- Moves for neighborhood quality do not rise in the same way.

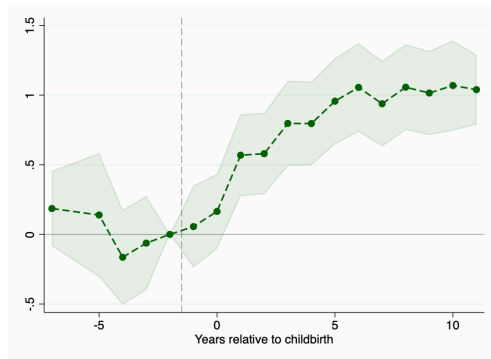
PSID: Ownership and Housing Size Around First Birth

Model: children raise required space and can move households toward ownership. $\hat{\alpha}_k$: change relative to $k = -2$.

$$Y_{it} = \mathbf{1}\{\text{owner}\}_{it}$$



$$Y_{it} = \text{number of rooms}_{it}$$



Homeownership rises sharply and occupied rooms expand after first birth.

Quantification

Dated Calibration

The model is estimated at a point along the 2007–2023 transition.

1. Derive the 2007 fertility intercept so a constructed old benchmark has completed fertility 2.1.
2. Reweight only the age marginal to the 2007 ACS household-head distribution.
3. Estimate a linear fertility-preference change from 2007 through 2023.
4. Impose Census household totals and ACS head-age shares at five dates.
5. Match twelve moments, principally measured on the simulated 2023 state.

The household-total and age bridge is an input, not a fit. It is retired after 2023 and replaced by the person/head transition law.

Externally Calibrated Parameters

	Param	Value	Source or restriction
<i>Timing</i>	Model period	4 years	Maintained
	Entry, maximum age	18, 85	Maintained
<i>Pref.</i>	σ	2.0	Maintained
<i>Finance</i>	ϕ	0.80	20% buyer equity
	ψ^s	0.06	Housing literature benchmark
<i>Housing</i>	Owner menu	{2, 4, 6, 8, 10}	ACS rooms distribution
	Rental cap	6 rooms	ACS rental distribution
	η	1.75	Saiz benchmark
<i>Entry</i>	Wealth distribution	PSID	Childless renters, ages 18–24

Internally Calibrated Parameters

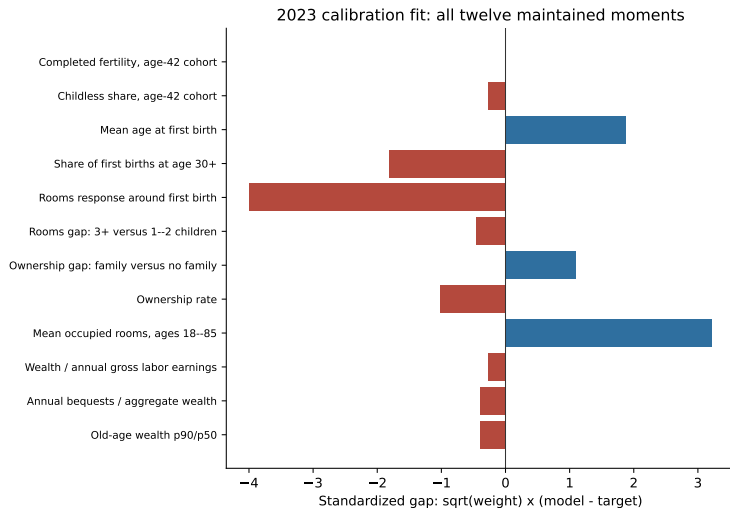
Param	Description	Estimate
β_{annual}	Annual discount factor	0.994959
κ_1	First-birth logit scale	2.267631
κ_C	Continuation-birth logit scale	1.765427
χ	Owner-service premium	1.033945
H_0	Housing-supply scale	16.381189
θ_0	Bequest scale	0.563219
θ_1	Bequest wealth shift	0.099707
h_m	Per-child room floor	0.315267
h_1	First-child room jump	0.199446
F_1	First-birth fixed cost	4.545167
$\Delta\psi_{2007:2023}$	Fertility-preference change	-0.350000

All eleven estimates are interior to their search bounds.

Calibration Targets

	Moment	Target	Model
<i>Fertility</i>	Completed fertility, women 40–44	1.918	1.918
	Childless share, women 40–44	0.188	0.186
	Mean age at first birth	26.045	26.327
	First births at age 30 or later	0.260	0.242
<i>Housing</i>	Four-year rooms contrast at first birth	0.720	0.380
	Rooms gap, 3+ versus 1–2 children	0.368	0.359
	Family ownership gap	0.168	0.177
	Ownership rate, ages 30–55	0.575	0.546
	Mean occupied rooms, ages 18–85	5.780	6.710
<i>Wealth</i>	Wealth / annual gross labor earnings	6.873	6.766
	Annual bequest flow / aggregate wealth	0.0088	0.0086
	Old wealth-to-income p90/p50	3.448	3.396

Calibration Fit



What the Calibration Does Not Match

The strict SMM loss is 36.099. Two housing moments account for 26.304, or 73% of the objective:

Moment	Target	Model
Four-year rooms contrast at first birth	0.720	0.380
Mean occupied rooms	5.780	6.710

- Fertility stocks, tenure, and wealth fit more closely than housing quantities.
- The weighted Jacobian has rank 10/11 at the predeclared 10^{-3} threshold.
- Its condition number is 1,104; the weakest direction loads primarily on the bequest shift θ_1 .
- The estimate is reproducible and interior, but locally weakly identified and not a claim of global optimality.

From the 2023 Fit to the Transition

Object	Annual tax	Rebate	Role
Calibration status quo	1%	None	Fitted 2023 reference
Transition reference	1%	Equal per head	Accepted forward path
Policy counterfactual	2%	Equal per head	Same equilibrium closure

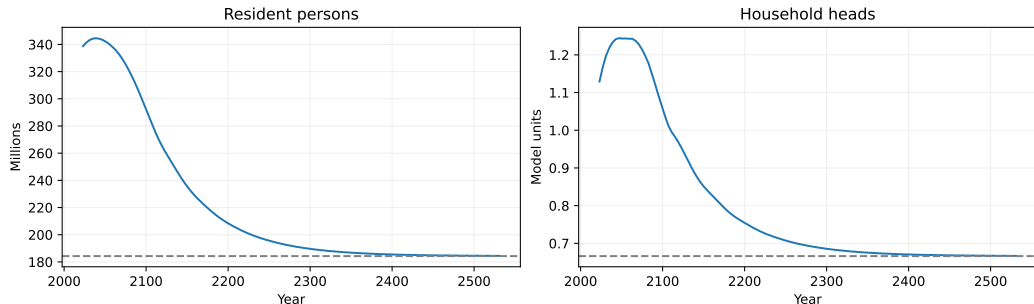
The accepted transition begins from:

338.7 million persons, 129.0 million heads, the fitted 2023 household state.

Supply is reanchored so the rebated 1% economy clears at the inherited quantity. The transition reference is rebated; it is not the unreputed calibration status quo.

Demographic Momentum

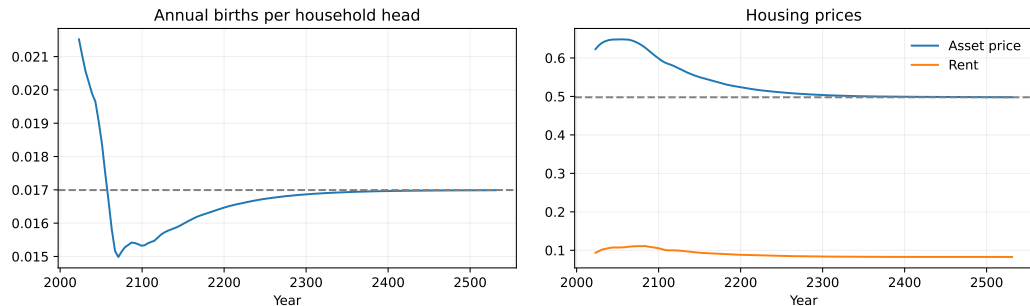
Rebated 1% property tax



Resident persons rise from 338.7 million in 2023 to 344.6 million in 2039. Household heads peak in 2047 at 142.1 million. Both stocks then contract toward the conditional terminal equilibrium.

An inherited age distribution generates decades of momentum even when subsequent births are low.

Prices and Births Move on Different Clocks



The asset price peaks in 2055. The renter price peaks in 2083 because it also reflects the next-period asset payoff. Annual births per head undershoot their terminal rate before converging back toward it.

Cohort composition, forward-looking capitalization, and household fertility need not turn at the same date.

The Conditional Terminal Equilibrium

Object	2023	Terminal	Change
Resident persons, millions	338.724	184.278	−45.6%
Household heads, millions	128.964	76.073	−41.0%
Asset price	0.6229	0.4977	−20.1%
Rent-equivalent price	0.0936	0.0825	−11.8%
Annual births per head	0.02152	0.01699	−21.0%

The terminal demographic renewal ratio is 0.5568. A constant positive population is sustained by the fixed age–sex migration flow.

This is a conditional fixed-migration equilibrium, not a forecast of the U.S. population level.

The Rebated Property Tax

The reform permanently raises the annual property-tax rate from 1% to 2% and returns all contemporaneous revenue equally across household heads:

$$\tau_t \int dG_t = \tau_{H,t} P_t Q_t^H, \quad Q_t^H = \int h_t(x) dG_t(x).$$

- **Capitalization:** a higher carrying cost tends to reduce the asset price.
- **User cost:** the renter price depends on the tax and the next asset price.
- **Tenure and fertility:** down payments, owner products, and child-space choices adjust state by state.
- **Demographic scale:** changed births affect persons now and household heads only later.

All effects are general equilibrium: prices, tenure, births, population, and the per-head rebate evolve together.

Conclusion

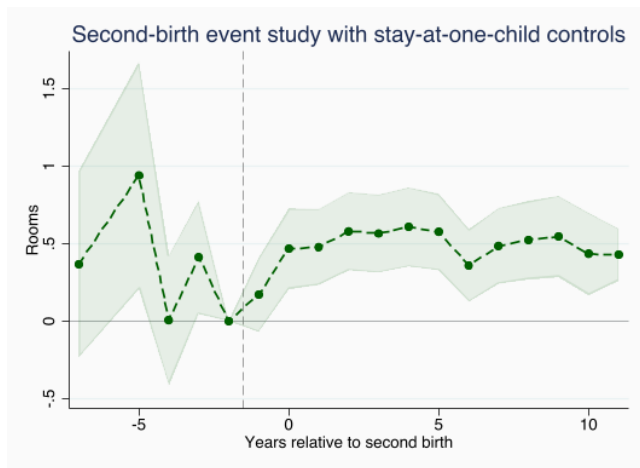
- Children raise demand for rooms; rental size and down payments determine access to that space.
- Fertility, tenure, saving, and old-age housing retention must be solved jointly over the lifecycle.
- Births create persons; survival, migration, and head formation create household heads.
- The calibrated model fits fertility stocks, tenure, and wealth more closely than housing quantities.
- The accepted transition displays demographic momentum followed by slow convergence to a conditional fixed-migration equilibrium.

Housing policy can affect family formation today and housing demand generations later.

Thank You

Appendix

PSID: Housing Also Expands After Second Birth



Baseline second-birth event study with stay-at-one-child controls: the +3 coefficient is about **0.57 rooms**. This disciplines housing demand, not a sequential second-birth fertility hazard.

Compact Household Derivation

The young household in the simple model solves

$$\max_{c,h,n} c + \alpha \log h + v \log n \quad \text{s.t.} \quad c + rh + [q + a(r + z)]n = y.$$

Interior first-order conditions give

$$h(r) = \frac{\alpha}{r}, \quad n(r, z) = \frac{v}{q + a(r + z)}, \quad d_Y(r, z) = \frac{\alpha}{r} + an(r, z).$$

Thus

$$\frac{\partial n}{\partial r} = \frac{\partial n}{\partial z} = -\frac{av}{[q + a(r + z)]^2} < 0.$$

The quantitative model preserves the cost channel but replaces continuous fertility, space, and tenure with sequential fertility, a rental cap, and a discrete owner ladder.

Access-Gap Interpretation

For a constrained renter, divide the housing first-order condition by the marginal utility of consumption:

$$\frac{u_h}{u_c} = r + \zeta_i^R, \quad \zeta_i^R \geq 0.$$

For an owner, the same gap separates the down-payment and size constraints:

$$\zeta_i^O = \underbrace{\frac{\mu_i}{\lambda_i}(1 - \phi)P}_{\text{financing}} + \underbrace{\frac{\theta_i}{\lambda_i}}_{\text{owner size limit}}.$$

If each child requires a units of space, $a\zeta_i$ is the shadow child cost generated by limited access. The gap is a local marginal valuation, not the welfare gain from an entire extra room.

Bellman Timing

Within a four-year date, the household:

1. observes fertility taste shocks and, when eligible, chooses whether to wait or attempt a birth;
2. realizes conception success and chooses renter rooms or an owner product conditional on parity;
3. chooses consumption and next-period liquid wealth;
4. receives income and pays rent, property tax, depreciation, and any moving cost;
5. ages children independently, transitions income, and survives or leaves a warm-glow estate.

In a transition, date- t policies use the date- $(t + 1)$ continuation value. The terminal value function and next-date asset price are boundary conditions; they do not replace convergence of the simulated terminal distribution.

Exact Annual Person Accounting

The annual law can be written cell by cell. For newborns,

$$N_{t+1}^{g,0} = s_{t+1}^{g,0} f_{t+1}^g B_{t+1} + M_{t+1}^{g,0}.$$

For interior ages $a \geq 1$,

$$N_{t+1}^{g,a} = s_{t+1}^{g,a} N_t^{g,a-1} + M_{t+1}^{g,a}.$$

The terminal age is top coded, so survivors from the penultimate and terminal cells both enter the last cell. Every step satisfies

$$\sum N_{t+1} = \sum N_t + B_{t+1} - \text{newborn deaths} - \text{existing deaths} + \sum M_{t+1}.$$

Exact Household-Head Accounting

Surviving heads are aged with the same survival schedule. In each cell, the target is $\rho^{g,a} N_{t+1}^{g,a}$. The accounting closure uses only one gross adjustment direction:

$$F_{t+1}^{g,a} = \max \left\{ \rho^{g,a} N_{t+1}^{\text{preM},g,a} - H_{t+1}^{\text{surv},g,a}, 0 \right\},$$

$$D_{t+1}^{g,a} = \max \left\{ H_{t+1}^{\text{surv},g,a} - \rho^{g,a} N_{t+1}^{\text{preM},g,a}, 0 \right\}, \quad H_{t+1}^{M,g,a} = \rho^{g,a} M_{t+1}^{g,a}.$$

Hence $H_{t+1}^{g,a} = \rho^{g,a} N_{t+1}^{g,a}$ exactly. Formation and dissolution are accounting flows, not simultaneous estimated hazards.

The Within-Age Household Bridge

Let $\tilde{G}_{t+1,a}(x)$ be the raw household transition within age a , and let $H_{t+1,a}$ be the head mass implied by persons. Then

$$G_{t+1,a}(x) = \begin{cases} H_{t+1,a} \frac{\tilde{G}_{t+1,a}(x)}{\int \tilde{G}_{t+1,a}(x') dx'}, & \int \tilde{G}_{t+1,a} > 0, \\ H_{t+1,a} \Gamma_a(x), & \text{for an empty entrant age cell,} \end{cases}$$

where Γ_a is the externally specified entrant template. The operation exposes added and removed mass separately and moves no mass across ages.

A richer model would estimate economic states for newly formed, dissolved, and migrant heads rather than preserve the raw conditional composition.

Steady-State Demographic Scale

With fixed terminal survival A , newborn-survivor vector f , net migration m , and headship vector ρ , persons satisfy

$$N^* = AN^* + f b^*(\rho' N^*) + m,$$

where b^* is annual births per head implied by household policy.

Define

$$v_B = (I - A)^{-1}f, \quad v_M = (I - A)^{-1}m.$$

The demographic renewal ratio is

$$\mathcal{R} = b^* \rho' v_B.$$

When fixed migration is positive, a finite steady state requires $\mathcal{R} < 1$, and

$$B^* = \frac{b^* \rho' v_M}{1 - \mathcal{R}}, \quad N^* = v_M + B^* v_B.$$

Market and Fiscal Closure

At every date, occupied physical rooms satisfy

$$\int h(x; \pi_t) dG_t(x) = H_{2023} \left(\frac{P_t}{P_{2023}} \right)^\eta.$$

The rebated tax satisfies

$$\tau_{H,t} P_t Q_t^H = T_t \int dG_t.$$

At a stationary price,

$$r^* = (R_b - 1 + \delta_H + \tau_H) P^*.$$

Housing demand uses physical rooms. The owner-service premium affects utility but does not create additional physical supply. Conditional renter housing is also distinct from realized housing after the tenure choice.

Complete Target Fit I

Moment	Target	Model	Gap	Weight	Loss
Completed fertility, women 40–44	1.918000	1.918251	0.000251	1,425.739	0.000090
Childless share, women 40–44	0.188000	0.185867	−0.002133	17,180.744	0.078133
Mean age at first birth	26.044627	26.327334	0.282707	44.444	3.552148
First births at age 30 or later	0.260327	0.242115	−0.018213	10,000.000	3.316971
Four-year rooms contrast at first birth	0.720246	0.379786	−0.340461	137.565	15.945664
Rooms gap, 3+ versus 1–2 children	0.367700	0.359253	−0.008447	2,958.515	0.211071

Completed fertility and childlessness are CPS age-42 cohort stocks. First-birth timing uses a fixed synthetic cohort. The rooms response follows the 2019 childless risk set through matched birth and no-birth branches to 2023.

Complete Target Fit II

Moment	Target	Model	Gap	Weight	Loss
Family ownership gap	0.167662	0.176866	0.009204	14,229.591	1.205562
Ownership rate, ages 30–55	0.575472	0.546060	−0.029412	1,207.846	1.044837
Mean occupied rooms, ages 18–85	5.779970	6.710105	0.930135	11.973	10.358582
Wealth / annual gross labor earnings	6.873100	6.766352	−0.106748	6.288	0.071648
Annual bequest flow / aggregate wealth	0.008800	0.008623	−0.000177	5,165,289.256	0.161538
Old wealth-to-income p90/p50	3.448111	3.396287	−0.051824	56.960	0.152979
Total strict loss					36.099223

All twelve moments enter the same active objective. The first-birth rooms row is retained as a descriptive contrast despite its non-flat prepath.

Free Parameters I

Parameter	Economic interpretation	Estimate	Search bound
β_{annual}	Patience	0.994959	[0.9400, 0.9995]
κ_1	First-birth logit scale	2.267631	[0.02, 50]
κ_C	Continuation-birth logit scale	1.765427	[0.02, 50]
χ	Owner-service premium	1.033945	[0.10, 5]
H_0	Housing-supply scale	16.381189	[0.20, 80]
θ_0	Bequest scale	0.563219	[0, 8]

No estimate is within two percent of its transformed search boundary.

Free Parameters II

Parameter	Economic interpretation	Estimate	Search bound
θ_1	Bequest wealth shift	0.099707	[0.02, 16]
h_m	Per-child room floor	0.315267	[0.10, 1.80]
h_1	First-child room jump	0.199446	[0, 0.50]
F_1	First-birth fixed cost	4.545167	[0, 8]
$\Delta\psi_{2007:2023}$	Fertility-preference change	-0.350000	[-1.50, 0.20]

The implied fertility intercepts are $\psi_{2007} = 0.280341$ and $\psi_{2023} = -0.069659$. The intercept change is a reduced-form residual, not a causally identified preference shock.

Assigned Household and Market Objects

Parameter	Value	Source or restriction
Model period	4 years	Timing
Entry and maximum ages	18 and 85	Timing
Risk aversion σ	2	Maintained
Financed share ϕ	0.80	20% buyer-equity restriction
Sale cost	6%	Housing literature benchmark
Owner room menu	{2, 4, 6, 8, 10}	ACS occupied-room distribution
Rental cap	6 rooms	ACS rental-size distribution
Supply elasticity η	1.75	Saiz benchmark
Entrant wealth	PSID ratio distribution	Childless renters age 18–24
Tenure taste-shock scale	0	Author restriction
Child dependence of bequests	0	Child-invariant warm glow

Historical Calibration Bridge

The 2007–2023 calibration uses five four-year dates. At each date, the observed household total and head-age marginal are imposed before the twelve maintained moments are evaluated.

- This absorbs household formation and migration that births since 2007 cannot generate by 2023.
- It makes the cross-section a dated state rather than a stationary distribution.
- Historical fertility, ownership, rooms, and price paths are holdouts unless explicitly included in the target system.
- The bridge is retired after 2023 and replaced by the person/head law.

Matching the imposed population path is an accounting identity, not evidence that the model explains U.S. household growth over 2007–2023.

Local Identification Audit

At the selected vector, the standardized residual is

$$r_j(\theta) = \sqrt{w_j} [m_j(\theta) - \hat{m}_j].$$

A fresh two-sided coordinate panel constructs the weighted Jacobian $J = \partial r / \partial \theta$.

Jacobian	Rank at 10^{-3}	Condition number
All 11 free parameters	10/11	1,104.01
Ten active columns after freezing the inconsistent bequest column	10/10	391.02

The weakest right-singular vector places 91.9% of its absolute loading on θ_1 . Local weak identification is concentrated in the bequest block.

Accepted Baseline Equilibrium Checks

Object	Max. absolute residual	Interpretation
Housing market	1.7943×10^{-4}	Demand relative to supply
Fiscal budget	1.1572×10^{-5}	Revenue minus equal transfers
Person identity	numerical precision	Births, deaths, and migration
Head identity	numerical precision	Deaths, formation, dissolution, migrant heads
Household/head identity	numerical precision	Household mass equals person-law head mass

The final endogenous date is also close to the independently solved terminal person distribution, head distribution, household distribution, price, rent, transfer, and fertility preference.

Slow Terminal Convergence

The dominant eigenvalue of the frozen-terminal four-year demographic block is

$$\lambda_1 = 0.960754.$$

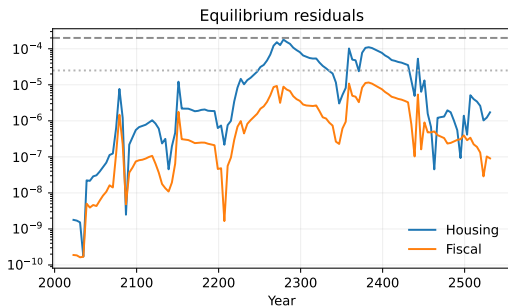
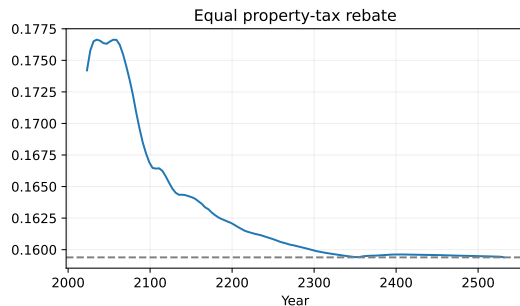
It implies

$$\text{half-life} = \frac{4 \log(1/2)}{\log \lambda_1} \approx 69 \text{ years}, \quad \lambda_1^{116} < 0.01.$$

Thus one-percent attenuation of the slow mode requires about 116 model periods, or 464 years. The accepted path uses 128 four-year periods so the simulated state approaches the terminal fixed point rather than merely inheriting it as a boundary condition.

The long horizon reflects age-structured demographic persistence, not a forecast horizon.

Baseline Transition Diagnostics



The equal rebate and equilibrium residuals are solved jointly with prices. The displayed residuals remain below their common acceptance thresholds throughout the path.

Policy Comparison Contract

A quantitative 2%–minus–1% comparison must hold fixed:

- the fitted 2023 household state and reconstructed person/head stocks;
- survival, net migration, birth sex shares, and headship;
- the housing-supply elasticity and 2023 supply anchor;
- the terminal fertility preference and all calibrated household parameters;
- the equal-rebate rule and the definitions of housing and fiscal residuals.

The comparison then separates the immediate response of prices, rents, tenure, and births from the delayed response of resident persons and household heads. No migration response or welfare ranking is part of this contract.

Interpretive Boundaries

- The first-birth rooms contrast is descriptive and has a non-flat prepath.
- The active calibration is locally weakly identified in the bequest block.
- Fixed 2023 headship is an accounting closure, not a structural formation model.
- Fixed 2100 migration in levels is essential to the positive terminal population scale.
- Static-elastic supply omits durable construction and asymmetric decline dynamics.
- One national market omits spatial sorting and local migration.
- The policy exercise reports equilibrium incidence, not welfare.

These limitations narrow the interpretation without changing the exact accounting distinction between persons, heads, and household economic states.

Selected Literature

Margin	Selected references
Lifecycle fertility	Becker and Lewis; Sommer; Doepke and Kindermann
Housing and childbearing	Lovenheim and Mumford; Dettling and Kearney; Hacamo
Housing supply and capitalization	Rosen; Roback; Saiz; Gyourko, Mayer, and Sinai
Housing tenure and user cost	Henderson and Ioannides; Sommer, Sullivan, and Verbrugge
Demography and housing demand	Mankiw and Weil; Francke et al.; Coeurdacier et al.
Spatial scale	Hsieh and Moretti; Rosen–Roback spatial equilibrium

The contribution is to combine the lifecycle housing–fertility mechanism with an explicit person-to-head demographic transition and jointly cleared housing and fiscal equilibrium.